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# Mapping Academic Exile: A Multi-Layer Network Model of German Refugee Scholars in Türkiye (1933–1955)

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## Abstract

This paper proposes a methodological framework for transforming biographical data into a multi-layer historical network model, using the case of German refugee scholars who took up academic positions in Türkiye between 1933 and 1955. This group, frequently examined within the broader field of intellectual migration (Ash 1999) and the support networks that shaped the trajectories of refugee academics across the 1930s (Löhr 2014), provides an exceptional opportunity to explore how exile, institutional integration, and disciplinary change can be visualized through network analytical techniques.

Existing scholarship has largely approached these scholars through intellectual history, exile studies, or institutional reform narratives, while the relational structures connecting actors, institutions, and disciplinary fields across time have remained comparatively underexplored (Hirsch 1982; Krueger 1986; Dölen 2010; Dağlı 2020; Medawar and Pyke 2001).

The study therefore asks: How can heterogeneous biographical information—such as reasons for exile, duration of stay, institutional affiliation, and academic output—be systematically modeled to reconstruct the temporal and structural dynamics of an academic diaspora?

The dataset consists of 70 German-speaking refugee scholars who worked in Turkish universities after the 1933 Law for the Restoration of the Professional Civil Service. Biographical variables include ethnic and religious background, political motives for flight, disciplinary fields, university and faculty appointments, and the chronological span of employment. The data are reconstructed from university archives, biographical lexica, memoirs, institutional reports, and publication records, allowing the combination of qualitative historical material with relational data extraction.

A multi-layer network design is implemented, combining (1) biographical–social relations, (2) institutional co-affiliation networks, and (3) thematic networks derived from teaching activities and publications. Temporal layers (1933–1940, 1941–1945, 1946–1955) allow the reconstruction of shifting institutional clusters and evolving collaboration patterns.

The model treats scholars not only as isolated biographical actors but also as mediators embedded within overlapping institutional, disciplinary, and political networks. This approach enables the visualization of how exile trajectories intersected with state-led university reform

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and knowledge circulation (Gibbons et al. 1994; Dustmann and Glitz 2005).

Preliminary results suggest that long-term stayers disproportionately shaped institutional clusters at İstanbul University and Ankara University, while politically motivated exiles formed distinct but partially overlapping knowledge networks with those fleeing racial persecution. Thematic clustering further reveals disciplinary convergence in medicine, law, and the humanities, indicating that exile fostered new intellectual constellations beyond traditional boundaries.

By reflecting on data limitations, ontological challenges, and visualization strategies (Borgatti, Everett, and Johnson 2018), the paper demonstrates how biographical approaches can enhance historical network analysis. The proposed model underscores the analytical value of integrating exile biography and institutional history, offering broader implications for reconstructing displacement-driven scientific networks.

More broadly, the paper contributes to current debates on academic displacement, transnational knowledge transfer, and the historical role of refugee scholars in processes of educational transformation and secular modernization. Rather than treating exile solely as a condition of rupture, the analysis conceptualizes academic displacement as a productive networked process that reshaped institutional and intellectual landscapes across national boundaries.

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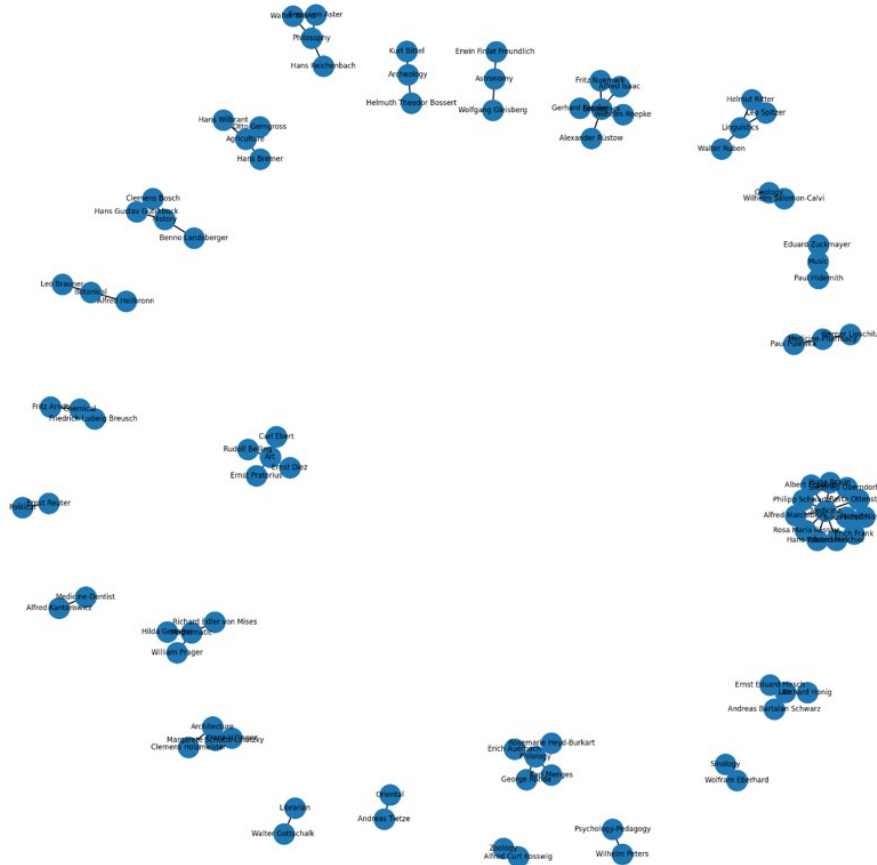


Figure 1 (cluster network – scholar only) Network clusters showing how German refugee scholars were grouped according to shared disciplinary fields in Türkiye (1933–1955). Each node represents an individual scholar. Edges indicate scholars who share the same disciplinary affiliation. The visualization highlights natural clustering patterns formed by disciplinary proximity, revealing how émigré academics concentrated in specific fields within the Turkish university system.

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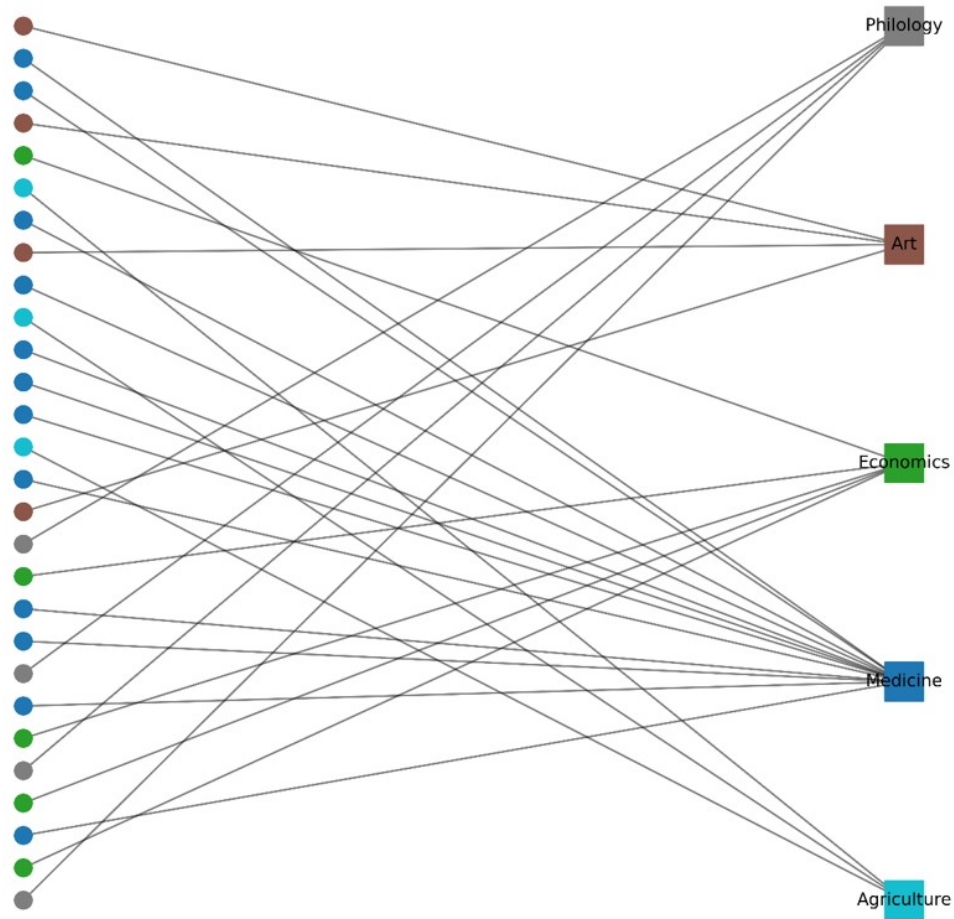


Figure 2 (bipartite, top 5 departments with colors) Bipartite network highlighting the five most represented academic departments among German refugee scholars in Türkiye (1933–1955). Circles denote scholars and squares denote departments; shared colors indicate disciplinary affiliation. The visualization reveals clear clustering patterns, particularly in Medicine and Agriculture, which formed the largest disciplinary hubs in the dataset.